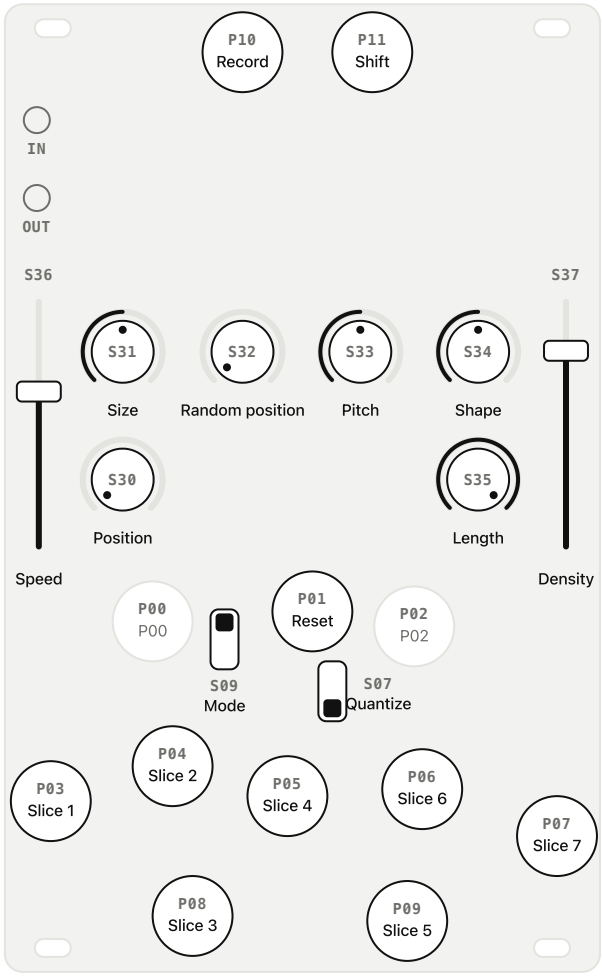
Simple Touch

Clessidra

It's the instrument where you pour grains of sound from single drops into a dense cloud.

francescodimaggio.nl/clessidra

Synthux Design Residency 2026



Record a sound, then play it as grains: Speed through it, Density how they fall.

Two layers: each knob alone, and its twin with P11 held. Nothing jumps when they change.

Density at its centre: no grains but the slices'. S09 at its centre: frozen.

FADERS AND KNOBS

S36	**Speed**. Playback speed, 0 to 4×, the pitch kept. Frozen, it scrubs through the loop. *P11*: **Dry/wet**. The input against the grains, dry to wet.
S37	**Density**. Grains at once, up to 16. None at the centre, regular below, random above. *P11*: **Reverb**. Reverb on the grains, from none to long tails.
S30	**Position**. Where the loop sits, from the recording's start to its end.
S35	**Length**. How long the loop is, from a sliver to the whole recording.
S31	**Size**. Grain length, 5 ms to 2 s, 100 ms at the centre. *P11*: **Random size**. Each grain a different length, up to two octaves either way.
S32	**Random position**. How far grains stray from the playhead, spreading across the stereo field.
S33	**Pitch**. Transpose up to two octaves either way, with stops at musical intervals. *P11*: **Random pitch**. Each grain a different pitch, up to an octave, snapped by Quantize.
S34	**Shape**. Grain envelope: reversed attack, smooth at the centre, sharp attack. *P11*: **Filter**. Low-pass below the centre, off at the centre, high-pass above.

PADS AND SWITCHES

S09	**Mode**. Forward, freeze or reverse. Frozen, Speed scrubs through the loop.
S07	**Quantize**. Snaps random pitch to octaves or semitones, or leaves it free.
P10	**Record**. Tap to keep the last 8 s, hold to record up to 30 s. With Shift: listen.
P11	**Shift**. Hold for each knob's second function, shown in orange.
P01	**Reset**. With Shift: second functions back to their defaults.
P03–P09	**Slices**. The loop in seven slices: its start, then the recording's strongest attacks inside it. Without attacks, as in a held note, even parts. Left to right on the board: P03, P04, P08, P05, P09, P06, P07. A touch: the playhead there, a grain at once, the beat from it. Held: it stays there.
P00, P02	Not assigned yet.

TO PLAY

Rhythm	Density below the centre, Shape up, Size short. Tap the slices: each restarts the beat
Drums by hand	Density at the centre: each slice plays one grain
Cloud	Density at the top, Random position up, Size long, Reverb (P11 + S37) up
Stretch	Speed at ¼ or ½, Density up. S09 down to hear it backwards
A moment held	S09 at the centre, Density up, a little Random position. Speed scrubs the point
Shimmer	Random pitch (P11 + S33) up, S07 up: octaves

LED

Glow	Grains falling, dimmer as the sand runs out
Flashing	Recording
Pulse	At a stop: unison, speed 1×, 100 ms, Hann, filter off
Steady	P11 held: the twin last turned